

infection. The friend's son's intention may have been good, but he ended up causing me a lot of anxiety that day.

'You do not take regular X-rays for treating a lung infection, maybe your doctor is making a fool of you,' he said, and referred my father to a lung specialist. Thankfully, the lung specialist was available for consultation only in the evenings. After the X-ray was done, my father called me to say he would be consulting the lung specialist recommended by his friend's son. I lost my temper and scolded him for listening to people who had no knowledge about these things.

'There is no need to see any other doctor, just get back home,' I told him. He agreed, but my trader's instinct told me I had ended up making him suspicious.

I immediately called Bina and asked her to have a word with him. Sure enough, he had made up his mind to see that doctor. Bina told him it was a good idea, and managed to get the doctor's contact details out of him. Somehow, I managed to get a call through to the doctor before he could see my father.

'Doctor, I know this may be against your ethics, but my father Mr – is coming to see you for a second opinion. He is suffering from cancer and does not have much time left. I have so far managed to conceal the fact from him. But if you were to diagnose him correctly today, he will lose his willpower to battle the disease. My humble request is that you do not tell him his true condition at any cost,' I told him.

God bless the doctor, he agreed to play along.

That evening my father was even more cheerful at the dinner table.

'I am sorry, Lala, but I did go to the doctor after all, just for my peace of mind,' he said.

'That's okay. What did the doctor have to say?' I asked him in an innocent tone.

'Well, he said it was a minor problem, and prescribed me a cough syrup. I picked it up on the way,' he told me.

Bina and I were relieved, but the stress of those few hours was unimaginable. I was glad I had not taken up any big positions earlier in the day.

The downtrend in the market continued, and the reasons were both internal and external. The currency crisis in Southeast Asia the previous year had crippled the economies of the Asian tigers like South Korea,